



PRELUDE
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Defence Training Needs Analysis Checklist

A practical, DSAT-aligned checklist for scoping, conducting and reviewing a Training Needs Analysis that finds the real gap, not just the symptom.

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BEFORE YOU START

About this checklist

A Training Needs Analysis is a decision-support process. Done well, it tells the organisation what performance is required, where the gap is, whether training will close it, and which option offers the best value. Done as a paperwork exercise, it delays decisions without improving them.

Purpose

Use this checklist to plan a TNA, to check progress during one, or to review a completed TNA before it is endorsed. It is written for individual training TNAs conducted under the Defence Systems Approach to Training (DSAT). Much of it applies to collective training and to non-Defence organisations, but JSP 822 sets out separate direction for collective training.

How to use it

1. Work through each of the thirteen sections. Tick **Done**, **Partly**, **Not done** or **N/A** for each check.
2. Record where the evidence can be found: a document reference, a register entry or a meeting record.
3. Treat every "Partly" or "Not done" as a question to answer, not a box to fill. Some will be acceptable risks in a proportionate TNA; record why.
4. Summarise the position on the summary page and record actions in the action log.

POLICY REQUIREMENT OR PRELUDE GUIDANCE?

Each check carries a basis tag. **JSP 822** marks a check that relates to a role, stage or product named in **JSP 822 Defence Direction and Guidance for Training and Education (V7.0), Volume 2: Defence Individual Training**. **PRELUDE** marks Prelude's practitioner guidance: good practice, not policy.

The tag shows where a check connects to policy. It does not reproduce or replace the policy text. JSP 822 distinguishes between what **must** be done (mandatory), what **should** be done (recommended; if it is not followed, the Senior Responsible Owner owns the resulting risk) and what **could** be done (good practice). Always confirm the exact requirement in the current edition and in any single-Service policy that sits beneath it.

EDITION CHECKED

References were checked against JSP 822 V7.0 as published on GOV.UK (Volume 2 v3.0, February 2024; publication page last updated 25 November 2025). JSP 822 is revised periodically. Check for a later edition before relying on these references.

Prelude Learning & Consultancy is independent. This checklist is not an official Ministry of Defence publication and has not been endorsed or approved by the MOD. Completing it does not demonstrate compliance with JSP 822.

CONTEXT

Where TNA sits in DSAT

DSAT is organised into four elements, supported by governance through the Management of Training System (MTS):

1 Analysis Training Needs Analysis: is training needed, and if so what and how?	2 Design Designing the training to meet the agreed requirement.	3 Delivery Conducting the training.	4 Assurance Evaluation and assurance that training is effective and remains so.
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The three stages of a TNA

JSP 822 Volume 2 describes the TNA in three stages:

Stage 1 Scoping • Scoping Exercise • Risk Register and Assumptions Register • Scoping Exercise Report	Stage 2 Analysis • Role Analysis and Role Performance Statement and/or framework • Training Gap Analysis • Initial Training Objectives • Training Options Analysis • Training Needs Report	Stage 3 Evaluation • Training Needs Evaluation, carried out within the Assurance element
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Key roles

Role	Summary
Training Requirements Authority (TRA)	Represents the end-user of the trained output. Owns the performance requirement (the Role Performance Statement and/or framework) and evaluates training effect.
Training Delivery Authority (TDA)	Responsible for training delivery, though not always for conducting the training itself. Leads design. Must be distinct from the TRA.
Training Provider	The school, college, unit or organisation that delivers the training.
TNA Steering Group	Provides governance and direction for the TNA where one is established.

Summaries are Prelude's paraphrase for orientation only. Refer to JSP 822 for the authoritative definitions and responsibilities.

Proportionality

Not every requirement justifies a full TNA. A minor change to an existing course may need only a short scoping exercise and a documented decision; a new platform or a safety-critical role may need the full analysis. Whatever the depth, the decision about depth should be explicit, recorded and owned.

THE CHECKLIST

Sections 1 to 13

1 Requirement definition and set-up

Establish why the TNA is needed, who owns it and how far it should go.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
1.1	The trigger for the TNA is recorded (new or changed equipment, role, policy, threat, structure or an identified performance shortfall).	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.2	The Training Requirements Authority (TRA), representing the end-user of the trained output, is identified.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.3	The Training Delivery Authority (TDA) is identified, and is distinct from the TRA.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.4	A sponsor or Senior Responsible Owner who will own residual risk is named.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.5	Governance for the TNA (for example a TNA Steering Group) and its terms of reference are agreed.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.6	A Scoping Exercise has been carried out to bound the analysis.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.7	Scope, exclusions, constraints, timescales and resources for the TNA are recorded in a Scoping Exercise Report.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
1.8	The depth of analysis is proportionate to the cost, risk and complexity of the requirement.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

2 Stakeholder engagement

Make sure the people who will use, deliver, fund and assure the training are involved early.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
2.1	Stakeholders are identified and mapped: TRA, TDA, training provider, end-user units, subject matter experts, equipment or project teams, finance and assurance.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
2.2	Roles and responsibilities for the TNA are agreed (a RACI or equivalent).	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
2.3	Subject matter experts with current operational experience are available for role and task analysis.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
2.4	The views of current role holders and their line managers are captured, not only those of headquarters staff.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
2.5	There is an agreed route for resolving disagreements about requirements.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

3 Operational context

Understand the environment in which the role will be performed.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
3.1	The operational or business outcome the role contributes to is stated.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
3.2	The environment, equipment, conditions and constraints in which the role is performed are described.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
3.3	Relevant doctrine, policy, safety and legislative requirements are identified.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
3.4	Planned changes (equipment, structures, concepts of use, manning) that will affect the role are identified, with dates.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
3.5	Interfaces with other roles, teams, Services or partners are understood.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

4 Performance requirements

Define what competent performance looks like before deciding how to achieve it.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
4.1	Role Analysis has been carried out to establish what the role holder must do.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
4.2	A Role Performance Statement (and/or framework) records the tasks, conditions and standards for the role.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
4.3	Standards are observable and measurable rather than descriptive.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
4.4	The Role Performance Statement is endorsed by the TRA.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
4.5	Performance requirements are traceable to the operational outcome identified in section 3.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

5 Role and task analysis

Break the role down to the level needed to make sound training decisions.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
5.1	Tasks are identified and broken down into sub-tasks where needed.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
5.2	Each task is assessed for difficulty, importance and frequency (DIF) or an equivalent prioritisation method.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
5.3	Safety-critical, high-risk and infrequently performed tasks are flagged.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
5.4	Tasks are validated with current role holders and subject matter experts.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
5.5	The analysis records which tasks need to be performed to standard on completion of training and which can be developed in the workplace.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

6 Knowledge, skills and attitudes

Identify what the role holder must know, be able to do and how they must behave.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
6.1	Knowledge, skills and attitudes (or behaviours) are identified for each task or task group.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
6.2	Underpinning knowledge is distinguished from knowledge that can be supported by job aids or reference material.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
6.3	Any qualifications, accreditations or licences required for the role are identified.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
6.4	Behavioural requirements (for example judgement, teamwork, leadership) are described in observable terms.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

7 Existing capability and gap analysis

Compare required performance with what the target audience can already do.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
7.1	The target audience is described: entry standard, experience, numbers and throughput.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
7.2	Existing training, qualifications and workplace experience are mapped against the requirement.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
7.3	A Training Gap Analysis identifies the difference between the required performance and the target audience's entry standard.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
7.4	The gap is supported by evidence (assessment data, observation, incident or performance data), not only by opinion.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
7.5	Initial Training Objectives are derived from the identified gap.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	

8 Training and non-training causes

Confirm that training is the right response to each part of the gap.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
8.1	For each significant gap, the analysis tests whether the knowledge or skill is genuinely missing.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
8.2	Non-training causes are considered: equipment, process, procedures, manning, workload, structure, leadership, information and incentives.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
8.3	Non-training findings are recorded and passed to the appropriate owner, rather than discarded.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
8.4	The analysis states which parts of the gap training is expected to close, and which it is not.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

9 Options analysis

Identify and compare the ways the training requirement could be met.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
9.1	A Training Options Analysis considers a realistic range of delivery options.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
9.2	Options include different methods and media: formal courses, workplace training, coaching, technology-enhanced learning, simulation and job aids.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
9.3	Options consider where and by whom training is delivered, and the balance between training establishment and workplace.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
9.4	Each option is assessed for effectiveness, cost (including whole-life cost), time, risk, capacity and supportability.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
9.5	The do-minimum option is assessed alongside more ambitious options.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
9.6	The recommended option, and the reasoning for it, is recorded.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

10 Evidence and assumptions

Make the basis of the analysis visible.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
10.1	A Risk Register and an Assumptions Register are maintained throughout the TNA.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
10.2	Sources of evidence are recorded and can be produced if challenged.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
10.3	Findings are labelled as evidence, inference or assumption.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
10.4	Assumptions with a significant effect on the recommendation have an owner and a date for validation.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

11 Governance and assurance

Make sure the analysis is approved, recorded and evaluated.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
11.1	Decision points and approvals are recorded, including who approved what and when.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
11.2	The Training Needs Report is submitted to and endorsed by the appropriate authority.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
11.3	Configuration control is in place for TNA products so later changes are traceable.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
11.4	A Training Needs Evaluation is planned to confirm, after implementation, whether the TNA met its purpose.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
11.5	Links to internal and external validation of the resulting training are identified.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	

12 Risks and dependencies

Understand what could prevent the recommendation from working.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
12.1	Risks to delivery (funding, instructors, equipment availability, estate, timescales) are identified and owned.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
12.2	Dependencies on equipment programmes, other TNAs, contracts or policy decisions are recorded.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
12.3	The residual training gap, and the risk of accepting it, is stated and owned.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
12.4	Safety and care and welfare considerations for the proposed training are identified.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

13 Recommendations and reporting

Present a clear, defensible recommendation.

#	Check	Basis	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A	Evidence / reference
13.1	A Training Needs Report sets out the analysis, options and recommendation.	JSP 822	☐	☐	☐	☐	
13.2	Recommendations are specific, costed where possible, prioritised and assigned to owners.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
13.3	Non-training recommendations are presented alongside training recommendations.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
13.4	The report states how success will be measured and when it will be reviewed.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	
13.5	The report can be understood by a decision-maker who did not take part in the analysis.	PRELUDE	☐	☐	☐	☐	

SUMMARY

Summary and action log

Count the responses in each section to see where the TNA is strongest and where it needs attention.

#	Section	Checks	Done	Partly	Not done	N/A
1	Requirement definition and set-up	8				
2	Stakeholder engagement	5				
3	Operational context	5				
4	Performance requirements	5				
5	Role and task analysis	5				
6	Knowledge, skills and attitudes	4				
7	Existing capability and gap analysis	5				
8	Training and non-training causes	4				
9	Options analysis	6				
10	Evidence and assumptions	4				
11	Governance and assurance	5				
12	Risks and dependencies	4				
13	Recommendations and reporting	5				

Action log

#	Check ref.	Action required	Owner	Due	Status
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					

Common pitfalls

- **Starting with the course.** The TNA is commissioned to justify a solution already chosen.
- **Desk-based task analysis.** Tasks are listed from documents without validation by current role holders.
- **Discarding non-training findings.** Equipment, process or manning issues are noted and then lost.
- **One option.** The options analysis compares the preferred option with nothing.
- **No evaluation plan.** Nobody can later say whether the TNA's recommendation worked.

Working with Prelude

Prelude's founder, Jason Smith, is a DSAT specialist with 23 years' Royal Navy service, including senior training and capability roles, and has led DSAT-aligned Training Needs Analysis on Defence programmes. Prelude supports TNA scoping, rapid and full TNAs, independent review of TNA products before endorsement, and capability work that sits around the TNA.

Rapid review

An independent check of a TNA at scoping or before endorsement.

Support to a TNA

Analysis capacity and DSAT experience alongside your team.

Discuss a challenge

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